Abdullah Becomes Numero Uno

On 5 March 1948, Mahajan finally vanished from the scene and with him, vanished the last hurdle in Abdullah's path to head an interim government. This was an interim regime which was to function till such time as constitutional provisions were made for a more formal system of administration, backed by some kind of a popular mandate. As head of this interim government, Abdullah continued to reveal his true colours. These were characteristics of his personality and behaviour to which Mahajan had already drawn the attention of Sardar Patel. They now began to bother Nehru and he could no longer ignore them.

The Maharaja also announced the formation of a constituent assembly in order to legitimise the new regime in Jammu and Kashmir. Interestingly, the Maharaja's proclamation had made it clear that the constituent assembly would also be a national assembly; it would be a legislature which would then proceed to create a constitution to validate its own existence. Even without a constitution, it could function as a fully sovereign body, within the parameters of the relationship with India, whatever exactly those might turn out to be. On 29 October 1947, the very day on which Abdullah began his emergency government, the Maharaja of Mysore, having acceded to India, set up a constituent assembly to draft a constitution for his state. The Mysore Assembly promptly passed a resolution that the state's constitution should be essentially what would then be framed by the Constituent Assembly of India for states of Mysore's class. Such a constitution was duly proclaimed by the Maharaja of Mysore on 25 November 1949 and it followed the pattern for what was called Part B states, as set out in Article 371 of the Indian Constitution. These were all former princely states that were to be treated on the same basis as the former provinces of the British Raj. The Maharaja of Kashmir was clearly following the Mysore model.

But Abdullah had very different ideas about what state constitutions ought to look like. He was not prepared to accept the Mysore model. Consequently, there existed considerable anxiety in New Delhi, Srinagar and Jammu about what he would do if he were pressed on the matter. He